of production in preindustrial societies. Over time, ownership of land, being the only real asset, became the manifestation of wealth.

Buildings constructed over land became the new real asset class. Industrialization led to further accumulation of capital in even fewer hands. In fact, land and buildings still remain a dominant part of the assets and wealth portfolio of the rich.

Land Use in Agriculture

The Ministry of Agriculture conducts land use surveys. As per the data available for the year 2015–16, the reporting area for land utilization was 307.75 million hectares of the total geographical area of India of 328.73 million hectares.

Land utilization is classified in nine broad categories.

The largest amount of land is used for sowing crops. The net sown area was reported to be 139.51 million hectares in 2015–16, which is in line with the decadal average of a little over 140 million hectares. There are two other categories of land considered fit for agriculture. These are fallow lands (agricultural lands that are kept uncultivated) and other uncultivated lands, excluding fallow lands. Fallow lands were reported to be 26.72 million hectares in 2015–16 and other uncultivated lands excluding fallow lands were counted as 25.64 million hectares. If we add up the net area sown, fallow lands and other uncultivated lands excluding fallow lands, total ‘agriculturable’ land becomes 191.87 million hectares, which is over 62 per cent of the reporting land mass of India.

The reporting land mass is also classified in two other categories: forest and land not available for cultivation. Forest land was recorded to be 71.87 million hectares, 23.35 per cent of the total reporting land mass.

The land classified as not available for cultivation was recorded at 44.02 million hectares, a share of 14.30 per cent. This land is further subdivided into two categories: area under non-agricultural uses and barren and